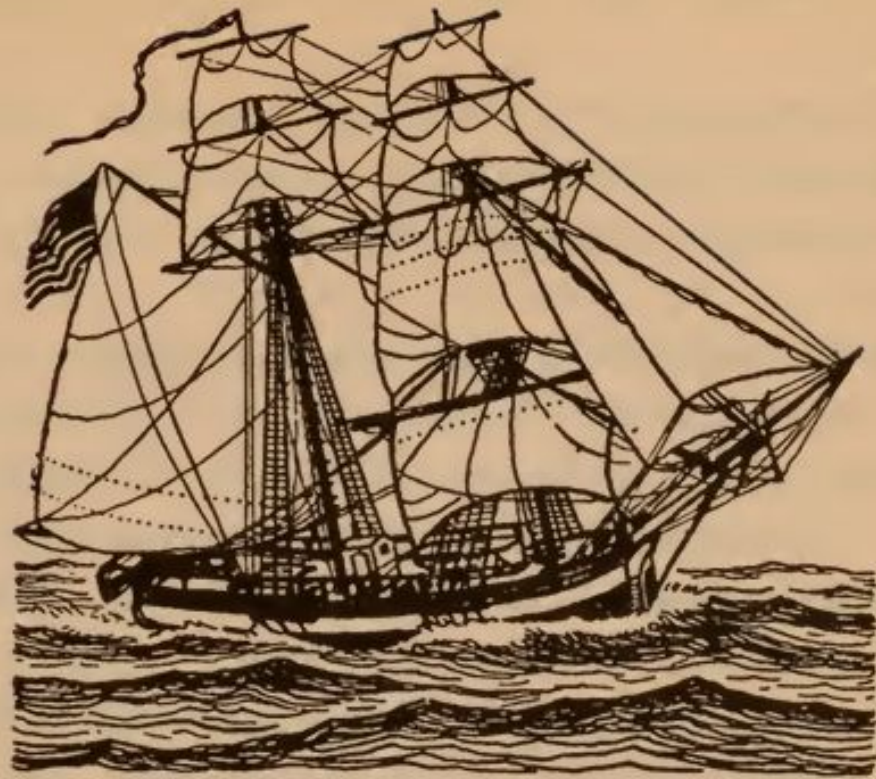


Carry On, Mr. Bowditch

Chapter 2



CHAPTER 2



THE PRIVATEERS

The first sunny day, when Nat came down to breakfast, he still had not thought of anything to do about his good-luck spell.

Through the open window he could hear a fife and drum, and a man shouting.

Father grinned. "They're drumming up a crew for another privateer!"

"What is a privateer?" Lizza asked.

"Just any kind of ship," Father told her. "It can be a sloop, a schooner, a square-rigger. A privateer doesn't carry cargo. It carries guns. When one of our privateers sees a British ship, we capture it, and take all the Englishmen prisoners. Then we put a prize master on their ship and sail it into port and sell it — ship and cargo."

Granny said, "Pirates! That's what they are!"

Father smiled. "I guess a privateer would be a pirate

in peacetime. But this is war. We only capture English ships."

"Or get captured ourselves." Granny sniffed.

Father chuckled and got up from the table. "I think I'll walk up to the wharves and see how they're getting along."

Granny looked at him over her glasses. "Stay out of the taverns, or you'll wake up on a privateer yourself."

Father laid his hand on Granny's shoulder. "Don't worry, Mother. I've turned over a new leaf."

Granny sighed. "I hope so. But take Nat with you; then you'll be sure to come back."

"Come along, son." They walked up Derby Street toward the wharves. The fife and drum got louder.

With one hand, Nat held on to Father's hand; with the other, he clutched the shilling in his pocket. "Father, if you had more money than you ever had before in all your life, what would you do?"

"I'd invest in a privateer. I'd buy an expectation from a sailor."

"How do you buy an expectation?"

"An expectation is the money a sailor expects to make on the voyage of a privateer. You see, when we capture a British ship, we sell it. The owner of the privateer gets part of the money. The rest of it goes to the captain and crew. If you want to buy an expectation, you talk to a sailor about it. He'll take your money. Then he'll give you a slip of paper that says you'll get part of what he makes on the voyage."

"And will that be more money than you gave him?"

"Lots more."

"Why will the sailor sell his expectation, when he would have more money if he didn't?"

Father chuckled. "Here comes a sailor now. You might ask him."

Nat saw the big man coming toward them in a flat black hat, a striped jersey, and wide trousers. Before the sailor was close enough for Nat to speak to him, he saw Father.

"Captain Bowditch!" he roared. "You're just the man we need!"

Father shook his head. "You wouldn't want me on your ship. I'm a Jonah. I'd bring bad luck."

"Stow it!" the sailor roared. "You're not the only man that's lost a ship on Anguilla Reef! Come on, Captain!"

Father shook his head again. "I'm going back to my trade."

The sailor argued a while, and then went on. Nat's father stood, staring out across the blue water. He shook his head quickly, as though trying to forget something. He reached for Nat's hand and smiled. "It's better, isn't it, son, to go back to my trade?"

"Yes, Father."

"Better to be a lucky cooper than an unlucky sailor?"

"Yes, sir, Father! Lots better to be a cooper. Uh — what's a cooper?"

Father chuckled. "He makes barrels." He stared out across the water again; his smile faded. "Barrels . . . " He sighed. "Come on, Nat."

On the wharf, the crowd thickened. Father picked up Nat and carried him out on the wharf. He stopped by a sea chest and stood Nat on it. "Here's a place for you, Nat, where you can see what's going on. Whoever owns the chest won't mind. You wait here for me."

Nat promised. Father disappeared into the crowd. Nat stood on the chest and stared up at the towering

masts of the ships, and the bowsprits, like long beaks, slanting into the air above him.

Men crowded the deck of the nearest ship, mounting guns. A privateer! Nat clutched his shilling and smiled.

A huge man with gray hair and a tobacco-stained grin stopped by the chest where Nat was standing. "Well, look what I've caught me!" he roared. "You shipping with me, Mate?"

Nat gulped, clutched his shilling, and tried to remember what to say. "I'm buying expectations."

The big man blinked. He rested his foot on the chest and leaned his hairy arm on his knee. "Expectations, eh? Now just what do you know about privateers?"

"I come from a long line of sea captains," Nat told him. "And I have a lot of money. I'm buying expectations."

The big man rubbed his whiskery jaw. "A lot of money, eh?"

“More money than I ever had before in all my life!
More than I ever had before all put together!”

The big man sat down by Nat. “Well, Mate, we might talk business.”

Nat pointed to the ship where men were mounting guns. “Are you sailing on that privateer?”

“Not that one, Mate. I’m sailing on the *Pilgrim*, out of Beverly.” He motioned with his thumb. “Beverly’s just across the water from here.”

“Is the *Pilgrim* a good privateer?”

“Best privateer that ever raked a Britisher with a broadside! You want to buy expectations from me?”

Nat’s heart pounded so hard he could not talk, but he nodded.

The big man took off his flat black hat and fished a paper from the crown. "Just got one left. For ten per cent of my expectations. What'll you give me for it?"

"All my money!" Nat laid his shilling in the big man's hand.

The big man stared at the shilling. "Well, I'll be a copper-bottomed, bevel-edged . . . Most money you ever had, eh?"

"Yes, sir!"

"And you come from a long line of sea captains? Who are you?"

"Nat Bowditch."

"Captain Bowditch's boy, eh? I remember when the *Polly* went aground. Same day the war started. April 19, 1775."

“Granny said it ‘took the tuck’ out of Father.” Nat told the big man about his good-luck spell that he was going to work, only the nor’easter came, and hid the moon.

The big man rubbed his bristling chin. He looked at the shilling. “It’s a bargain, Mate. But keep it a secret! Don’t ever tell any man that Tom Perry sold a tenth of his expectations for a shilling! They’d stow me in the brig. What’s worse, they’d put me on the binnacle list!”

Nat didn’t know what he was talking about, but he promised. “I’ll tell no man!” He took the slip of paper, folded it, and put it in his pocket.

Tom Perry stood. He flipped the shilling into the air, caught it, and grinned. “I’ll drink to our success, Mate!” He ambled away, his big shoulders making holes in the crowd.

Nat sat on the chest and waited for his father. A secret!

He must tell no man! But he could tell Lizza. Lizza always kept a secret. He'd have to have someone to talk to. If he didn't, he'd burst! Just think! Nat Bowditch — with a share in a privateer! His chest felt too big for his ribs.

When Nat and Father got home, Nat found Lizza weeding the garden. He showed her the paper, and told her about Tom Perry.

“Oh, Nat! That's wonderful! How soon will you get your money?”

“I don't know. Let's ask Father.” They went in the house.

Father smiled. "How long before a privateer comes back? It all depends. Maybe in a few months, maybe in a year, maybe longer."

Granny sniffed. "And maybe never."

Nat and Lizza went back to the garden. Lizza whispered, "A year! Maybe two years!"

"Maybe never."

Lizza said, "Granny's just a little — well — fussy about the ocean. You're not worrying, are you, Nat?"

Nat squared his shoulders. "No, not a bit worried. Not a bit." But he looked at his slip of paper, and wondered.